

North America



Many ancient herbal traditions in North and Central America not only withstood the influx of European settlers but helped to reinvigorate Western herbalism. In parts of Central America herbal medicine is widely practiced, and in the U.S. and Canada it is again enormously popular.

Stretching from the Arctic wilds of Canada and Alaska to the tropical regions of Panama, North and Central America cover diverse geographical regions and harbor an immense variety of medicinal plants. Most of them are indigenous, but others—such as nutmeg, ginger, and tamarind—were introduced from the Old World from the 16th century onward. Likewise, native American medicinal plants—such as corn, cocoa, cayenne, and sunflower—were introduced to Europe, Asia, and Africa. This trade of species was an important part of the interplay between the Old and New Worlds' herbal traditions.

Herbal Traditions in Central America

Herbal medicine is commonly practiced in rural areas of Central America, especially in Guatemala and Mexico. In the Mexican tradition, loss of “balance” between hot and cold elements within the body is thought to be the underlying cause of illness, and the healer’s art is to restore balance and vitality.

Mexican herbal medicine is not a static tradition, but has evolved from a shifting blend of Aztec, Mayan, and Spanish influences. Long before Hernando Cortez and his conquistadors came ashore in 1519, the Mayan and Aztec cultures had a well-developed understanding of plant medicines. The *Badianus Manuscript*, the first American herbal (written by an Aztec, Martin de la Cruz, in 1552), lists the medicinal uses of 251 Mexican species. They include damiana (*Turnera diffusa*, p. 144), taken by the Maya as an aphrodisiac, and mesquite (*Prosopis juliflora*), used by the Aztecs as an eye lotion. Both species are still used medicinally, alongside European herbs such as pennyroyal (*Mentha pulegium*, p. 235) and thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143). It is thought that approximately 65 percent of the plants used today by traditional Mexican herbalists originated in Europe.

In other Central American countries efforts are being made to encourage people to use herbal medicine as the first line of treatment for illness. Projects in the Dominican Republic and Nicaragua, for example, are teaching women how to use local herbs within their communities, while in Cuba doctors routinely prescribe medicinal herbs to make up for the scarcity of conventional medicines.

Caribbean Herbal Medicine

Throughout the Caribbean, domestic herbal medicine remains popular. Some of the widely used herbs include fever grass or lemon grass (*Cymbopogon citratus*, p. 198), which, as its name suggests, is used to treat fevers, and kerala (*Momordica charantia*, p. 236), a creeping vine that is prized as a “cure-all” on many of the islands. Kerala has been shown to have an ability to lower blood-sugar levels and may help to slow down the

Corn silk (*Zea mays*, p. 154) is a remedy for problems affecting the urinary system.

Slippery elm (*Ulmus rubra*, p. 145), soothes the mucous membranes.

Saw palmetto (*Serenoa repens*, p. 136) has an antiseptic effect within the urinary tract.

Saw palmetto tincture

Saw palmetto dried fruit

Prickly ash bark

Gravel root (*Eupatorium purpureum*, p. 209) is a traditional Native American remedy for urinary tract problems.

Prickly ash (*Zanthoxylum americanum*, p. 153) is a warming remedy that is used to treat poor circulation.

Prickly ash berries

Prickly ash leaves